

Cereal presents Part III of

CADENCE

A Faerie Tale by Robert Mac Kay

...I rambled horrid thoughts of angry retribution, anger at the Mother and my brain for failing me when I was so close to my goal. I even went so far as to blame dear sweet Snapper for my condition, when I concluded: no, not Snapper, but another.

This is by no means a confession, but here is what I did. I first made two weapons, one that would launch a needle a great distance with amazing accuracy, a weapon faeries used many years ago and a weapon stolen by man. The other was made from a great gear from a clock, one half of it sharpened to a clean blade and fastened to the crook of a stick. I put these weapons in my sack, dropped to the ground, and the hunt began.

On several outings to the local raspberry bush, I was able to observe the movements of my friends in and out of the thicket. It is true that I wept upon seeing them dancing in airy delight from leaf to leaf, berry to berry. I hid in the underbrush in shame, taking what fruit I could find near the ground, peeping under leaves at my friends. The blue haired was always there. It took me nearly several days of following and tracking to know her routine.

Everyday at mid-day, she would frequent, like most of us, a pleasant pool of clear water, to bathe and drink. It was a hard travel for me from my home to the pool and I missed her three times before deciding to camp there overnight. Well, I decided against it, fearing shrews, and left early the next morning.

I was perched in the crook of a small tree, sheltering myself from the rain that had traveled in. And as much as it disturbed me, I coated myself in mud to hide my Cara, so that the blue haired could not sense my approach. To my delight, she lit to the branch in front of me. She stood there, staring down at the pool, giggling at the rain while I readied my weapons. I stood and aimed my needle. Though she didn't really see me the movement startled her, and she prepared to take flight. She cleared three lengths from the branch when I let the needle fly. I stung her right in the shoulder and she let out a cry and spun to the Earth. I gasped, fearing that I may have undone myself with the shot. I descended the tree to investigate.

I came upon the blue haired sputtering blood and crawling on her belly, her legs broken. Most of the mud and washed off but I still must have been a frightful sight, because the blue haired saw me and cried again. I knelt beside her, and marveled at my shot. Every time I pulled on the needle, even a little, she would let out little mewling sounds. I hushed her.

I told her:

"Now you know. Now you see how things are, and now I'm on his side. But I will not laugh. Hush, now. I will help you."

I chopped first into her head then twice into her back to relieve her of her moanings and squealings and, more importantly, her wings.

The wings were fine, I dare say, more splendid than my own, and I went to great pains to preserve them, fearing I might be forced to commit another beastly act of murder. I coasted them in fine mouse fat and cauterized their ends.



Thus, I returned to flight. At first ungainly, now quite elegant. I, however, did not return to faeriedom, as now I was a creator of machines and had given the blue haired her quietus. I feared the fate of Promethea, who betrayed other faeries by giving our secrets to man, yet savages, who was tied to the Earth for the crows to fill their gullets. Even though my wings were stained with the Cara of the blue haired, they were machines. And if they should fail, I would be unprepared to relive my life as it was now, and would surely perish.

I would thus maintain my rituals and gather my food, now quite dear to me and preferred over faerie sweets. I would remain in isolation, as was surely my destiny, only now to break the silence and tell my story in hope of it landing on sympathetic ears, and to tell others my reasons for machines and my life with them. I now retreat with some fear for my life, in danger of persecution, hopeful that my intellect may preserve my future as it has surely delivered me from my past.

And so, in conclusion, it is enough to say that I have seen Cadence in my home from time to time. I've set aside a dish for her filled with those tiny items I have no use for, but that she finds so precious.... In return, she has, too, given me a gift through her company and I pledge to be as she: to see the world and its possibilities as I will, true to myself in the face of convention, to seek wisdom in nature and in my own mind, and to be wary of those who cannot be swayed by reason, but instead, cling to the archaic dogma of those long dead.

-The End-

About the Author:

Robert Mac Kay, born 25 March, 1972, native of Rochester NY, currently living out his three year sentence in Pittsburgh, PA, under an assumed life, but really he's only fooling himself. This April, he hopes to escape to the wild land of Virginia Beach, living the sweet fat life of a married man. He also wants it noted that he does not intend "Cadence" to be lumped together with the mass faerie lore, and does not, therefore, apologize for and terms or notions "known" to be contrary to the world of Faerie. He believes

that faeries are public domain enough to bear his intrusion, and besides, if you read this only to see what every other story has to say, then why did he write it?

About the Story:

The story of "Cadence" is based on a series of full sized sculptures created by the Author utilizing natural and mechanical media. Parties interested in viewing the pieces or making a purchase should direct and inquiry's to the Author via migst7+@pitt.edu or care of *Cereal*.

Currently, the Author is working on a sequel to "Cadence," complete with another set of sculptures. Whether the story is to appear in *Cereal* is still unknown.

About the Artwork:

Due to the sudden and unavoidable loss of the illustrator just as "Cadence" was going to press, the images appearing in the story are not those expected by the Author or the staff of *Cereal*.



Special thanks to Otto Vondrak for providing the gothic border appearing in each issue. Images of Cadence's wings and gears are actual photographs from sculptures created by the Author. Composite images were created by Sean Hammond in an attempt to help capture the mood of the story and stay true to the character sketches of Cadence provided by the original illustrator.

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